

Ingredients for Success

Essential Elements for Lasting Change

Assessment Questions: Evaluate whether the essential ingredients for success are present in your community and situation.

About This Tool

Across the communities where ecological restoration has taken hold, certain conditions show up repeatedly. Some are social: shared awareness of the problem, committed local leadership, the capacity to work through resistance. Others describe the relationship between community and ecosystem: memory of how things once were, diversity that provides options, a willingness to let nature recover on its own terms. EcoTipping Points calls these the Ingredients for Success.

The ten ingredients aren't a checklist to complete before you can act. They're a diagnostic lens. Some will be present in your situation; some will be weak or absent. Knowing which is which shapes what's possible and where to put your energy.

What This Tool Does

Each ingredient page helps you assess whether that condition exists in your community, identify strategies for building on what's already there, and decide how to respond when something critical is missing. Use the ingredients after your Reverse It session, as a way to stress-test candidate interventions before committing to a first step.

The Ten Ingredients

Each ingredient includes guidance on how to recognize it, amplify it if present, build it if absent, or work around it when necessary.

Outside Stimulation and Facilitation

Communities that can draw on outside knowledge and support (without ceding control) move further faster.

Shared Community Awareness and Commitment

A community's shared understanding of a problem and how to address it, including collective ownership and commitment.

Harmony Between Community and Ecosystem

Restoration efforts must work with both natural systems and community needs, creating mutual benefit that sustains itself.

Enduring Commitment of Local Leadership

Restoration takes years. Communities that succeed have people willing to stay committed through skepticism, setbacks, and slow progress.

Letting Nature Do the Work

Ecosystems know how to recover. The most powerful strategies don't fight nature; they get out of its way.

Mobilizing Community Commitment

Using powerful symbols and rapid results to build and maintain community engagement.

Overcoming Social Obstacles

Every restoration faces resistance. Communities that succeed find ways through it with strategy, solidarity, and persistence.

Social and Ecological Diversity

Diversity is insurance. Communities and ecosystems with more variety have more options and paths forward when conditions change.

Social and Ecological Memory

The past holds blueprints. Communities and ecosystems that can draw on what worked before have a head start.

Building Resilience

Success doesn't protect itself. Communities that build resilience are prepared for disruptions that will come.

Using Ingredients with Systems Thinking

The ingredients work alongside the systems thinking tool, not ahead of it. Once your community has identified candidate interventions in Reverse It, the ingredients help you evaluate them: what's already in place that gives an intervention real traction, and what's missing that could undermine it. Identify candidates first, then use the ingredients to refine your choice.

